were ‘non-cultivating owners of land’, also described as ‘agricultural rent receivers’.

Real GVA at factor cost in agriculture, forestry, mining and quarrying at current prices was Rs 5274 crore in 1951 (53 per cent of total GVA of Rs 10,036 crore). The per-capita income of 295 million people living in rural areas in 1950–51 was only about Rs 180. Too many people living in rural areas dependent upon land cultivation and earning a very low income was the root cause of India’s abject poverty at the time of Independence. Poverty, malnutrition and disease were rampant in rural India.

The country also inherited a highly lopsided distribution of land. A great majority of people, the peasants, worked on lands controlled by relatively fewer landlords. They earned a pittance as wages and small share in produce for their backbreaking work. Much of the crop or proceeds of the crop went to the landlords and the government as revenue. Too little per-capita availability of land, also unevenly distributed, provided fertile ground to create widespread sentiments of class injustice in the country.

Land Reforms Find No Mention in the Constitution

As the ruling party the Indian National Congress (INC), the Constituent Assembly and the leadership did not develop a commonly shared understanding of the land reform agenda even in the years immediately following Independence, no land reform agenda was built into the Constitution. There was no declaration about the abolition of the zamindari system and establishing a direct relationship between the state and the tiller of the land in the document. Nor were there any provisions about agriculture ceiling or converting tillers’ tenancy rights into ownership.

The Constitution only incorporated two related aspirations in the directive principles of state policy—even these did not refer to land reforms and agriculture directly. Article 39 (b) enjoined the state to direct its policy towards securing ‘that the ownership and control of material resources of